

Chapter One

The Lamb in Egypt

Four hundred years. That is how long the descendants of Abraham had been in Egypt — and for a great portion of that time, they were slaves. The promise God made to Abraham still stood, but the people who carried it were making bricks for a king who did not know Joseph and did not care about the God of Israel.

And then, after four centuries of silence, God moved.

He sent a man named Moses. He sent plagues — ten of them — each one a direct challenge to the gods Egypt worshiped, each one escalating, each one met with Pharaoh's stubborn refusal to let the people go. The Nile turned to blood. Frogs covered the land. Gnats. Flies. Livestock struck dead. Boils on every Egyptian. Hail that shattered trees. Locusts that devoured what was left. And then darkness — three days of darkness so thick you could feel it pressing against your skin.

Nine plagues. Nine refusals.

And then God told Moses what the tenth would be. This one was different. This one would not strike the water or the livestock or the sky. This one would strike families. The firstborn son in every household in Egypt would die — from the throne of Pharaoh to the dungeon of the lowest prisoner.

But God did not simply announce the plague and let it fall. He gave Israel a way through it.

And the way through it was a lamb.

What God told Moses that night is recorded in Exodus 12. If you have never read it slowly, I want to invite you to do that now — because these instructions are not just ancient history. They are an architectural drawing. A blueprint. And every line in that blueprint points to something that would be built fifteen centuries later in Jerusalem.

Let me walk you through it.

The Selection

“Speak to all the congregation of Israel, saying, ‘On the tenth of this month they are each one to take a lamb for themselves, according to their fathers’ households, a lamb for each household.’”

— **Exodus 12:3**

The lamb was not chosen at random. It was not grabbed from the flock at the last minute. God specified the day — the tenth of the month. In the Hebrew calendar, this month was Nisan, the first month of the religious year, falling roughly in our March or April.

On Nisan 10, every household in Israel was to go to the flock, examine the animals, and select one. From that moment, the lamb was set apart. It belonged to the household. It had been chosen for a purpose.

The Inspection

“Your lamb shall be an unblemished male a year old; you may take it from the sheep or from the goats. You shall keep it until the fourteenth day of the same month.”

— **Exodus 12:5-6a**

The lamb had to be unblemished. No defect. No injury. No disease. This was not a suggestion — it was a requirement. A blemished lamb would not do. The sacrifice had to be perfect.

And notice the timing. The lamb was selected on the tenth, but it was not killed until the fourteenth. That is four days. Why the wait? The text does not tell us explicitly. But the requirement of perfection was already stated — the lamb had to be without blemish. Keeping it in the household

for four days, where it could be watched and handled daily, would give the family every opportunity to confirm what they believed when they chose it. If something was wrong with the lamb, four days would reveal it.

But four days would do something else, too. The lamb comes into the home. The children see it. They feed it. They touch it. For four days it lives among them — and then it dies for them. By the time Nisan 14 arrives, this is not an abstraction. The family knows this animal. The cost of the sacrifice is personal.

Whether God intended the four-day period for confirmation, for attachment, or for both, we are not told. What we can say is that He required it. He could have commanded the lamb to be selected and killed on the same day. He did not. He built a gap into the design — and that gap matters.

Hold that detail. We are going to need it later.

The Killing

“Then the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel is to kill it at twilight.”

— Exodus 12:6b

The NASB translates the Hebrew phrase as “at twilight.” The literal Hebrew is *bein ha’arbayim* — “between the evenings.” Jewish tradition understood this to mean the afternoon hours, roughly between three o’clock and sundown. That was when the Passover lamb was to be slaughtered. Not in the morning. Not at midnight. In the afternoon of Nisan 14.

God did not leave the timing to the household’s convenience. He specified when the lamb was to die — down to the part of the day.

The Blood

“Moreover, they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and on the lintel of the houses in which they eat it.”

— Exodus 12:7

The lamb had to die. But the death alone was not enough. The blood had to be applied. It had to be taken and placed on the doorposts and on the lintel

— the top and sides of the doorframe. It had to be visible. It had to be where it could be seen.

This is the detail that sets the Passover apart from every other sacrifice in the Old Testament. The blood was not poured on an altar. It was not sprinkled inside a tabernacle — there was no tabernacle yet. It was put on the door of the home. Right there at the threshold between death outside and life inside.

The blood was the dividing line.

The Promise

“The blood shall be a sign for you on the houses where you live; and when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt.”

— **Exodus 12:13**

Read that again slowly. *When I see the blood, I will pass over you.*

That is the Passover. Not a holiday. Not a tradition. A transaction. The lamb died so the firstborn would not. The blood on the door was the evidence that a death had already occurred in that house — the lamb’s death in place of the son’s.

And when the angel of death passed through Egypt that night, he did not check whether the family inside was good enough. He did not ask whether they had been faithful enough, obedient enough, or deserving enough. He looked for one thing.

Blood.

Where there was blood, he passed over. Where there was not, the firstborn died.

The Meal

God did not stop at the blood. He gave specific instructions for what the family was to do that night.

“They shall eat the flesh that same night, roasted with fire, and they shall eat it with unleavened bread and bitter herbs.”

— Exodus 12:8

“Do not eat any of it raw or boiled at all with water, but rather roasted with fire, both its head and its legs along with its entrails. And you shall not leave any of it over until morning, but whatever is left of it until morning, you shall burn with fire.”

— Exodus 12:9-10

The lamb was to be roasted whole — not raw, not boiled. It was eaten with unleavened bread and bitter herbs. Whatever remained by morning was to be burned completely. Nothing was to be left over. Nothing was to be wasted. God specified every detail of how this meal was to be prepared and consumed.

The text does not tell us why God required roasting rather than boiling, or why bitter herbs were included. What it tells us is that He required them. These were not suggestions. They were instructions from God for the most important night in Israel’s history, and He did not leave the menu to the household’s preference.

“Now you shall eat it in this manner: with your loins girded, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand; and you shall eat it in haste — it is the Lord’s Passover.”

— Exodus 12:11

They ate standing up. Dressed for travel. Staff in hand. Ready to move the moment the word came. This was not a leisurely dinner. This was the meal of people who knew that before the night was over, everything was going to change.

The Leaven

There is one more instruction connected to this meal that deserves its own attention, because God gave it unusual weight.

“Seven days you shall eat unleavened bread, but on the first day you shall remove leaven from your houses; for whoever eats anything leavened from the first day until the seventh day, that

person shall be cut off from Israel.”

— Exodus 12:15

“Seven days there shall be no leaven found in your houses; for whoever eats what is leavened, that person shall be cut off from the congregation of Israel, whether he is an alien or a native of the land. You shall not eat anything leavened; in all your dwellings you shall eat unleavened bread.”

— Exodus 12:19-20

This was not a matter of convenience. It was a command — and the penalty for breaking it was being cut off from the people of God. Leaven was to be physically removed from the house. Not just avoided. Removed. For seven full days, no leaven was to be found anywhere in the dwelling. No exceptions. No distinction between Israelite and foreigner. Everyone under that roof lived without leaven for the duration.

It is worth noting that this command was given *before* the departure from Egypt. When the Israelites later left in haste and their dough had not risen (Exodus 12:39), that was the historical circumstance of the night. But the command to remove leaven and eat unleavened bread was already in place. God required it — it was not simply a result of being in a hurry.

The text does not tell us what the leaven represented. But centuries later, the apostle Paul — writing to Christians in Corinth — made a connection that reaches all the way back to this night:

“Clean out the old leaven so that you may be a new lump, just as you are in fact unleavened. For Christ our Passover also has been sacrificed. Therefore let us celebrate the feast, not with old leaven, nor with the leaven of malice and wickedness, but with the unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.”

— 1 Corinthians 5:7-8

Paul saw leaven as a picture of sin — something that works its way through the whole lump, something that must be removed, not merely managed. And he connected it directly to the Passover: “Christ our Passover also has been sacrificed.” The Passover lamb and the removal of leaven were part of the same event, the same night, the same set of instructions from God. Paul saw them as part of the same picture.

Whether Paul was revealing what God always intended by the leaven command or drawing a Spirit-guided application from it, we can say this much: the removal of leaven was serious enough that God attached the severest of consequences to it. It was not incidental. It was woven into the Passover from the beginning.

The Command to Remember

And then God did something that tells you this night was never meant to be a one-time event.

“Now this day will be a memorial to you, and you shall celebrate it as a feast to the Lord; throughout your generations you are to celebrate it as a permanent ordinance.”

— **Exodus 12:14**

A permanent ordinance. Throughout your generations. God commanded Israel to reenact this night every year, on the same date — Nisan 14 — so that no generation would ever forget. The lamb. The blood. The door. The death that passed over because a death had already taken place.

And they did. Every year for fifteen centuries, Israel killed a Passover lamb on Nisan 14. Every year the blood was shed. Every year the meal was eaten. Every year the story was retold — parents to children, generation after generation.

And every year, whether they fully understood it or not, they were rehearsing something that had not yet happened.

Because the Passover lamb was never the point.

It was the picture.

The Blueprint

Step back for a moment and look at what God laid out in Exodus 12. Not as ancient history — as a blueprint. An architectural drawing for something that would be built fifteen centuries later.

A lamb is selected on a specific day — the tenth of the month.

The lamb must be without blemish — no defect of any kind.

The lamb is kept for four days — from the tenth to the fourteenth.

The lamb is killed at a specific time — the afternoon of the fourteenth.

The blood must be applied — visibly, publicly, right there at the threshold between death and life.

The blood is what saves — not the merit of the household, not their track record, not their worthiness, but the blood on the door.

All leaven must be removed — completely, from every corner of the house, under penalty of being cut off.

And the event is to be remembered permanently — reenacted every year on the same date, so that when the real Lamb finally arrives, the pattern will be unmistakable.

I want you to hold this blueprint in your mind. Every detail. The day of selection. The four days of keeping. The requirement of perfection. The afternoon killing. The blood that makes the difference between life and death. The leaven that must be removed.

Because in the chapters ahead, we are going to open the final week of Jesus' life and lay it beside this blueprint. And what we will find is not a loose resemblance. It is not a vague echo or a poetic parallel.

It is a point-by-point, day-by-day, hour-by-hour fulfillment — so precise that no human hand could have engineered it.

The pattern was set in Egypt. The fulfillment happened in Jerusalem. And the God who designed both is the same God who told Moses, on that first Passover night, to put the blood on the door.

That is what this book is about. Not a theory. Not an interpretation. A blueprint — and the Lamb who fulfilled it.